



Meta Ads Policy 2026

Privacy Violations & Personal Attributes — Complete Compliance Guide

Updated May 2026 | Covers Facebook, Instagram, Messenger & Audience Network



CORE POLICY

What Is Meta's Personal Attributes Policy?

Ads must **never** assert or imply knowledge of a user's personal attributes. This rule protects user privacy and prevents discriminatory targeting across all Meta platforms.

Platform Scope

Facebook, Instagram, Messenger & Audience Network

Consequences

Ad rejection, account warning, or **permanent ban**

Prohibited Personal Attributes

Ads cannot assert or imply knowledge of any of the following user characteristics:



Race & Ethnicity

No ethnic or racial targeting signals in copy or imagery



Religion & Beliefs

Faith-based assumptions are strictly off-limits



Age

Cannot imply or assume user's age group or life stage



Sexual Orientation & Gender Identity

Zero inference allowed on orientation or gender expression



Disability & Health

Physical and mental health conditions cannot be assumed



Financial Vulnerability

Vulnerable financial status and bankruptcy signals banned



Voting & Political Status

Voting behavior or party affiliation cannot be inferred



Criminal Record

Past legal history is a fully prohibited inference category



Trade Union Membership

Union affiliation and labor associations are off-limits

What Ads CAN and CANNOT Say

The distinction is subtle but critical — shift focus from **user conditions** to **product benefits**.

✗ NOT ALLOWED

"Are you **struggling with debt?**"

"Meet other **Christians** near you"

"Struggling with your **weight?**"

"Other people **like you...**" (implying shared traits)

✓ ALLOWED

"Explore tools for **smarter financial planning**"

"Join our **faith-based community**"

"Discover **healthy lifestyle tips**"

Broadly reference location: "American" or "New Yorker"

The Biggest Policy Change of 2026

⊗ **Effective March 4, 2026:** Personal attributes detection has been dramatically expanded. AI now evaluates **implied meaning**, not just literal words. A headline that implies a condition — without stating it — is flagged.

Indirect Language Flagged

Inference and indirect phrasing now violate policy, not just explicit claims

Health Inference Banned

Disability and sensitive health condition inference now automatically flagged

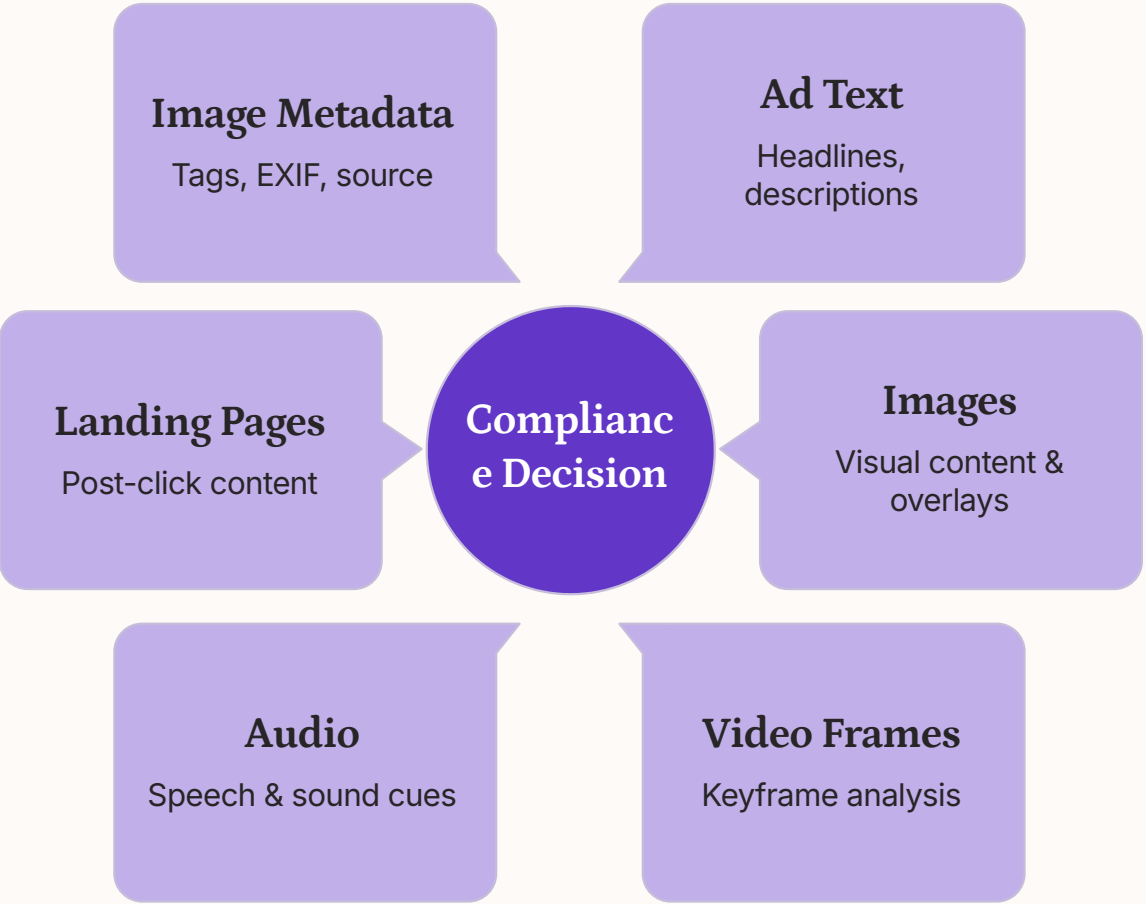
Semantic Intent Detection

AI evaluates the implied meaning behind ad copy across all surfaces



Multimodal AI Enforcement System

Q1 2026: Meta's AI compliance engine now scans every asset simultaneously as a single compliance unit — not in isolation.



34% spike in rejection rates for health, wellness & beauty brands vs Q4 2025



Cross-Asset Correlation

All elements reviewed together — a compliant headline won't save a flagged image



Human Review Escalation

Multi-layer flags routed to human reviewers: **48–72 hour delay**

Mandatory AI Content Disclosure

Effective April 7, 2026 — Advertisers must clearly disclose AI-generated content in regulated categories before the first impression is served.



Synthetic Faces

Ads using fully AI-generated faces must carry a disclosure label



AI-Generated Voices

Any synthetic voiceover must be explicitly disclosed to viewers



Photorealistic AI Images

Photorealistic AI product imagery requires a visible disclosure tag



Advertiser Verification

New verification window required before first ad in **Healthcare, Finance, Gambling & Alcohol**



📦 CRACKDOWN — MAY 2026

Health & Wellness Policy Tightened

Effective May 5, 2026 — Meta's enforcement net now catches implied transformations, not just explicit before/after comparisons.

Implied Transformations Banned

Showing a product next to a fit person = traditional before/after violation

Testimonial Videos

Videos describing a "journey" can now independently trigger a violation

Weight Loss & Supplements

Claims face stricter substantiation requirements across all formats

Lead Ads Restricted

Sensitive data field restrictions broadened well beyond healthcare

Custom Audiences & Privacy Rules

Significant restrictions introduced in **September 2025** reshape how advertisers build and use custom audiences with sensitive data.

Blocked Audience Segments

Health Terms

"diabetes", "cancer",
"mental health" —
blocked from September
2, 2025

Finance Tags

"credit score",
"bankruptcy" — removed
from custom audience
targeting

Key Rule Changes

- Pixel data for mid & bottom-funnel actions no longer shareable in restricted categories
- **December 2025:** AI chat conversations opened to ad personalization — EU, UK & South Korea excluded pending GDPR compliance

Special Ad Categories: HEC Rules 2026

Housing, Employment & Credit — the strictest targeting restrictions in the Meta ecosystem, now expanded with new category inclusions.

Auto-Detection

Multimodal image + text + landing page scan. Keyword workarounds no longer bypass enforcement

Location Targeting

Minimum 15km radius required. City-level exclusions are prohibited

Audience Restrictions

Lookalike audiences disabled — broad targeting only. Age capped at 18–65+ (auto-applied)

NEW in 2026

BNPL, crypto lending & student loans now require HEC category selection

